



GOVERNANCE

CITIZEN'S CHARTER

MODULE - 13

BASIC CONCEPT OF CITIZEN'S CHARTER

1 In any liberal democratic society, the quality service provided by the government is one of the key principles that ensure an inclusive, sustainable and equitable development.

2 When such service is provided with unparalleled levels of transparency, accountability and responsiveness, it enables the citizens to cooperate in the developmental process towards achieving effective growth.

3 It is here that the concept of Citizen's Charter plays a vital role.



BASIC CONCEPT OF CITIZEN'S CHARTER

4 The prime objective of issuing a Citizen's Charter by an organization is to improve the quality of services offered.

5 The Citizen's Charter is not legally enforceable and therefore, is non-justiciable. However, it acts as a tool for facilitating the delivery of services to citizens with specified standards, quality and time frame, etc., with commitments from the Organization and its clients.



OBJECTIVES BEHIND CITIZEN CHARTERS

- 1 Appropriate statement of service standards based on public expectations.
- 2 Simplification of rules, regulations, guidelines and working norms for better delivery of services.
- 3 Time bound grievance redressal of citizens.
- 4 More independent and impartial grievance redressal.
- 5 Consistent and continual improvement in quality of services to the beneficiaries.



PRINCIPLES OF THE CITIZEN'S CHARTER

The six principles of the Citizen's Charter movement as originally framed were as follows:

- i** **QUALITY:** Improving the quality of services
- ii** **CHOICE:** To be offered wherever possible
- iii** **STANDARDS:** Specifying what to expect and how to proceed if standards are not met
- iv** **VALUE:** For the taxpayers' money

- v** **ACCOUNTABILITY:** Individuals and Organisations
- vi** **TRANSPARENCY:** Rules/Procedures/Schemes/Grievances



RATIONALE OF A CITIZEN'S CHARTER

- 1** Citizen's Charter is a written, voluntary declaration made by organizations about service standards, choice, accessibility, non-discrimination, transparency and accountability.
- 2** However, wide the range of services may be, it should be in accordance with the expectations of citizens.
- 3** Therefore, it becomes one of the most efficient ways of defining the nature of services offered and standards of service delivery.



RATIONALE OF A CITIZEN'S CHARTER

4 Citizens are entitled to expect a minimum quality of service as they fund the government either directly or indirectly through taxes.

5 They would like to be assured that the price they pay is reasonably compensated with the quality and quantity of services provided.

6 A Citizen's Charter serves this purpose as it acts as the meeting point of the expectations of the citizen and the level of service provided by the organizations.



RATIONALE OF A CITIZEN'S CHARTER

7 Another major significance of Citizen's Charters is that it helps in instilling a sense of duty into the minds of public officials, rather than being tyrants who hold power.

8 If successfully implemented, the Charter can enable the following:

- i Improved service delivery
- ii Greater responsiveness of officials towards the public
- iii Greater public satisfaction with services



INTERNATIONAL CONTEXT

1 The **United Kingdom** was the first country to introduce the Citizen's Charter initiative.

2 Following suit, many other countries started implementing similar programmes.



CITIZEN'S CHARTER IN INDIA

- 1 The concept of Citizen's Charter made its entry into India in 1997.
- 2 It was introduced at the conference of Chief Ministers, 1997, held at Delhi.
- 3 One of the outcomes of the conference was the decision to formulate Citizen's Charters, especially in those sectors that have a large public interface (eg: Railways, Telecom, Posts, Public Distribution systems etc).



INADEQUACIES AND GROUND REALITIES AFFECTING CITIZEN'S CHARTER

- 1 Inadequacies in bringing changes in the work culture of the organization.
- 2 Lack of impartial and independent or effective ombudsman system.
- 3 Prevailing culture of corruption, non-transparent, procedural control and bureaucratic control.
- 4 Formulation of Charters without following a consultative process.



INADEQUACIES AND GROUND REALITIES AFFECTING CITIZEN'S CHARTER

5 Lack of knowledge on the philosophy, goals and main features of the Charter, among service providers.

6 Poor publicity given to the Charters.

7 Lack of public awareness of the concept of Citizen's Charter.

8 Charters are rarely updated, revised or reviewed.

9 In some cases, Charters have become a one-time exercise, frozen in time.

10 Citizen Charters have still not been adopted by all ministries/department.



SUGGESTIONS FOR STRENGTHENING CITIZEN'S CHARTER FOR MORE EFFECTIVE GOVERNANCE

The following are the suggestions for strengthening citizen's charter for more effective governance.

- 1 Involving stakeholders in fixing standards.
- 2 Creating awareness among people.
- 3 Clear channel of hierarchy to be mentioned for effective grievance redressal.
- 4 Independent and impartial Ombudsman for grievance redressal.



SUGGESTIONS FOR STRENGTHENING CITIZEN'S CHARTER OR MORE EFFECTIVE GOVERNANCE

5 To change the culture of organization to training them in client orientation and participatory management.

6 The need for citizens and staff to be consulted at every stage of formulation of the Charter.

7 The need for creation of database on consumer grievances and redress.

8 The need for wider publicity of the Charter through print media, posters, banners, leaflets, handbills, brochures, local newspapers, etc., and also through electronic media.



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